

FIFA World Cup: Memorabl...

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Mexico City Stadium

An aerial view of the Mexico City Stadium, officially named Estadio Banorte (formerly Estadio Azteca). The stadium hosted the opening match of the FIFA World Cup 2026 on June 11. Mexico is hosting t...

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Carlos Alberto Torres, World Cup winner Brazil's football team captain Carlos Alberto Torres holding the Jules Rimet Trophy aloft after his team's triumph at the 1970 World Cup. [...\(more\)](#)

The **FIFA World Cup** is a quadrennial [football](#) (soccer) tournament of men's national teams that determines the sport's world champion. It is organized by the [Fédération Internationale de Football Association](#) (FIFA) and is likely the most popular sporting event in the world, drawing billions of [television](#) viewers every tournament. Countries [worldwide](#) compete vigorously, many years in advance, to host the lucrative event, and accusations of bribery connected to the awarding of hosting rights have long shadowed the tournament. In fact, the [2015 FIFA corruption scandal](#) implicated more than two dozen [FIFA](#) officials and their associates in a 24-year self-enrichment scheme that reached the highest levels of [FIFA](#) management. The equivalent tournament for women's national football teams is the [Women's World Cup](#).

In early 2024 FIFA announced [the full 2026 World Cup](#)

[schedule](#). The final is scheduled for July 19 at MetLife Stadium in East Rutherford, [New Jersey](#), which has been rebranded as New York New Jersey Stadium for the event.

More About Football and the World Cup



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History



The History Behind the FIFA World Cup Watch this video to learn more about the history of the FIFA World Cup.

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The first World Cup was organized in 1930 by FIFA and was won by [Uruguay](#). Held every four years since that time, except during [World War II](#), the competition consists of international selection tournaments leading to a final event featuring the national teams that have qualified. Unlike [Olympic](#) football, World Cup teams are not limited to players of a certain age or [amateur](#) status, so the competition serves more nearly as a contest between the world's best players. Referees are selected from lists that are submitted by all the national associations.



Britannica Quiz
Great Moments in Sports Quiz

The trophy cup awarded from 1930 to 1970 was the [Jules Rimet Trophy](#), named for the president of FIFA who proposed the tournament. This cup was permanently awarded in 1970 to then three-time winner [Brazil](#) (1958, 1962, and 1970), and a new trophy, called the FIFA World Cup, was put up for competition.

Famous Footballers



Diego
Maradona



Lionel
Messi



Cristiano
Ronaldo



Zinedine
Zidane



2026 FIFA World Cup

The [2026 FIFA World Cup](#) is taking place in [North America](#) from June 11 to July 19, with matches in 16 cities across the [United States](#), [Mexico](#), and [Canada](#). The 2026 edition is the first time that three countries are cohosting and only the second time that more than one country has done so ([Japan](#) and [South Korea](#) teamed up to host the 2002 World Cup). It is also the first tournament to feature 48 teams, an increase from the previous 32. In the first round, teams are divided into 12 groups of 4 teams each, and each team in a group plays a round-robin of three games. The three hosts will play their group stage matches in their respective home countries. The top 2 teams from each group (24 total) will advance to the knockout round. The top 8 third-place teams (based on points scored, goal differential, and other [criteria](#) if necessary) will likewise advance, for a total of 32 teams. Because of the larger field, this World Cup will last 39 days instead of the roughly 32 days of previous tournaments. The teams will play a total of 104 matches (72 in the group stage and 32 in the knockout stage). The group stage matches are listed in the calendar below. ([Read more about the tournament's format, groups, and schedule.](#))

2026 FIFA World Cup schedule

Game times based in Central Time

All

Mexico

Canada

United States

June 2026

Source: FIFA.com.

Memorable World Cup moments

During its nearly century-long history, the World Cup has delivered many exciting records, achievements, and upsets. Read on for a list of memorable and historic moments related to the competition.

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Uruguay 1930

July 13: The first FIFA

13 Famous Footballers Who Have Never Won a World Cup

World Cup began in Uruguay with only 13 teams.

Read about the players who have [never lifted football's biggest trophy](#).

[France](#) vs.

Mexico and the United States vs. [Belgium](#) were held simultaneously, becoming the first matches. France's Lucien Laurent scored the first World Cup goal.

July 15: During the [Argentina](#) vs. France match, Brazilian referee Gilberto Rêgo blew the whistle early, signaling the end of the fixture in the 84th minute instead of the 90th. The players, who had left the field, were recalled and played the final six minutes after a [delay](#).

July 30: Hosts Uruguay beat Argentina 4–2 in the final to win the first men's World Cup.

Italy 1934

Footballer Luis Monti completed one of the tournament's most unusual personal feats by appearing in World Cup finals for two different countries, playing for Argentina in 1930 and then Italy in 1934.

March 25: [Italy](#) played and won a World Cup qualifier, becoming the only host country ever to have to play in a qualifying tournament, as future hosts were automatically granted a slot in the main World Cup.

May 24: Despite Mexico already having qualified for the main World Cup, FIFA ordered the team to face off against a late-entering United States in a sudden-death playoff in [Rome](#) three days before the World Cup began. Mexico lost the match and was replaced in the main draw by the United States.

May 27: [Egypt](#) became the first [African](#) and first [Arab](#) country to appear at a World Cup.

June 7: [Germany](#)'s Ernst Lehner scored against [Austria](#) 25 seconds after kickoff, setting the [fastest-goal mark](#) in World Cup history at the time.

June 10: Italy defeated [Czechoslovakia](#) in the final to win its first title and become the first champion from [Europe](#).

France 1938

March: [Austria](#) was removed from the final [roster](#) after the [Anschluss](#), handing [Sweden](#) a bye in the first round.

June 5: The [Dutch East Indies](#) (now [Indonesia](#)) became the first [Asian](#) team to appear at a World Cup and also became the only national team to play only one match at the World Cup (since the tournament was played in a straight knockout format). The team lost 6–0 to [Hungary](#) in its lone match in 1938 and has never qualified for the main tournament again.

June 5: Brazil defeated [Poland](#) 6–5. Polish footballer Ernst Willimowski became the only player to score four goals in a World Cup match and still be on the losing team.

June 19: Italy beat Hungary 4–2 in the final and became the first team to win back-to-back World Cups, as well as the first team to win two World Cups.

1942–46



FIFA World Cup records This is an infographic highlighting prominent records set at FIFA World Cups, accurate until the 2022 edition.

The World Cups scheduled for 1942 and 1946 were canceled because of World War II.

Because of the [hiatus](#), Italy reigned as the world champion for a 16-year span until the tournament resumed in 1950, despite having only won two World Cups (1934 and 1938).

Brazil 1950

The World Cup returned after a 12-year hiatus.

[India](#) qualified for the World Cup but withdrew before the main tournament, in part because of financial and logistical difficulties.

June 29: The United States shocked [England](#) 1–0.

July 16: The Uruguay vs. Brazil final match at the [Maracanã Stadium](#), [Rio de Janeiro](#), drew the [largest crowd](#) for any football match in history. Uruguay scored an upset 2–1 win over Brazil to earn its second World Cup. The match became known as the “El Maracanazo” (the Maracanã smash).

Switzerland 1954

Hungary scored 27 goals in the tournament, which is the [highest number of goals](#) scored by a team in a single World Cup.

January: After the [Spain](#) vs. [Turkey](#) (Türkiye) qualification playoff was inconclusive, a blindfolded schoolboy, Luigi Franco Gemma, drew lots to decide which team would advance to the World Cup. Turkey won the lucky draw and made its tournament [debut](#).

June 26: Austria beat [Switzerland](#) 7–5 in what was the [highest-scoring match](#) in men’s World Cup history.

June 27: The Hungary vs. Brazil match is known as the “Battle of Bern,” one of the most violent and unsportsmanlike matches in tournament history.

July 4: [West Germany](#) (now Germany) beat favorites Hungary in the final match, called the “Miracle of Bern,” to win its first World Cup.

Sweden 1958

France’s Just Fontaine scored 13 goals in 6 matches, setting a [single-tournament scoring record](#) that still stands.

June 11: Brazil vs. England became the first scoreless match in World Cup history.

June 29: Brazilian footballer [Pelé](#) became the first teenager, and [youngest player](#) ever, to score in a World Cup final.

June 29: Brazil beat [Sweden](#) 5–2 in the final to win the World Cup for the first time.

Chile 1962

June 2: [Chile](#) vs. Italy became the [infamous](#) “Battle of Santiago,” one of the most violent matches in World Cup history.

June 2: Czechoslovakia’s Václav Mašek scored against

Mexico after 15 seconds, setting a new [fastest-goal record](#) that stood until 2002.

June 10: West Germany and [Yugoslavia](#) met in the World Cup quarterfinals for a third consecutive time, having played against each other in 1954 and 1958 as well.

June 17: Brazil beat Czechoslovakia 3–1 in the final to retain the title.

England 1966

World Cup Willie became the first official tournament mascot.

July 19: [North Korea](#) beat Italy 1–0 in one of the greatest shocks in World Cup history.

July 23: [Portugal](#) overturned a 3–0 deficit against North Korea to win 5–3, with star Portuguese footballer [Eusébio](#) scoring four times in the match.

July 30: Geoff Hurst scored the first hat trick in a World Cup final.

July 30: England beat West Germany 4–2 after extra time to win its first World Cup, though there has been a fierce debate over whether Geoff Hurst's controversial second goal actually crossed the line. At the 2010 World Cup, a similar goal-line refereeing decision went Germany's way against England. (See below "[Lampard's ghost goal](#).")

Mexico 1970

1969: The [Central American](#) qualifying tournament was held against the [backdrop](#) of the so-called [Soccer War](#) between [El Salvador](#) and [Honduras](#), with both countries engaging in a short-lived but intense military conflict a few weeks after competing against each other in the World Cup qualifiers.

Yellow and red cards were introduced to the World Cup.

June 17, 1970: Italy beat West Germany 4–3 after extra time in the semifinal known ever since as the "game of the century."

June 21: Brazil beat Italy 4–1 in the final to win a third title and earned permanent possession of the Jules Rimet Trophy.

West Germany 1974

The FIFA World Cup Trophy, which replaced the Jules Rimet Trophy, was awarded for the first time.

June 14: [Australia](#) became the first [Oceanian](#) team to appear at a World Cup.

June 22: [East Germany](#) beat West Germany 1–0 in a politically charged fixture in [Hamburg](#) during the [Cold War](#). This was the only time the two teams played against each other at the World Cup.

June 22: In a match against Brazil, the Zaire ([Democratic Republic of the Congo](#)) football team had been told by the country's president, [Mobutu Sese Seko](#), not to lose by more than four goals. With 15 minutes left to play and trailing 2–0, Brazil was awarded a free kick in a scoring position. Unconventionally, Zaire defender Mwepu Ilunga ran out from the defensive wall and kicked the ball away before the game was restarted in an attempt to run down the clock. Zaire ultimately lost the match 3–0.

June 22: During the Australia vs. Chile group stage match, referee Jafar Namdar showed Australian player Ray Richards two yellow cards but neglected to show the automatic red card to eject the player from the game. Richards became the first footballer to continue playing despite being shown two yellow cards. He was sent off after fourth official Clive Thomas alerted the referee. A [similar incident](#) occurred at the 2006 World Cup.

July 7: West Germany beat tournament favorites the [Netherlands](#) 2–1 in the final to win the World Cup. Referee Jack Taylor made history by awarding both the first and second penalty kicks in World Cup final history, one each to the Dutch and West German teams.

Argentina 1978

June 11: Scottish player Archie Gemmill scored a brilliant solo goal for [Scotland](#) against the Netherlands. Collecting the ball on the right side of the pitch, Gemmill cut inside on his left foot, skipped past three Dutch defenders, and buried a curling shot in the back of the net.

June 21: Argentina's 6–0 win over [Peru](#) became one of the most controversial results in World Cup history, with [suspicions](#) of match fixing lingering decades later.

June 25: Argentina beat the Netherlands after extra time in the final to win the World Cup for the first time.

Spain 1982

June 15: Hungary beat El Salvador 10–1, the only double-figure score by a team in men's World Cup finals history. During the match Hungary's László Kiss scored the fastest hat trick in World Cup history, scoring in the 69th, 72nd, and 76th minutes. Kiss was also the first player to achieve the feat as a substitute player.

June 16: [Algeria](#) beat West Germany 2–1 on its World Cup debut—one of the greatest upsets in tournament history.

June 21: During the [Kuwait](#) vs. France group stage match, the Kuwaiti team claimed it had heard a whistle and stopped playing, which allowed France to score a goal. The Kuwaiti players walked off the pitch in protest when the referee refused to disallow the goal. Sheikh Fahad al-Ahmed al-Jaber al-Sabah, a prince of Kuwait and president of the Kuwaiti football association, [descended](#) to the pitch from the stands and spoke with the referee, following which the goal was disallowed before the resumption of play.

June 25: The West Germany vs. Austria match was dubbed the “disgrace of Gijón” for the lackluster display. Both teams tacitly refused to use attacking play for most of the match in order to preserve a favorable result that would allow them both to advance to the knockout stage at the expense of Algeria. The match changed the way the World Cup scheduled its fixtures, with the final group games played at the same time to prevent collusion between teams.

July 8: West Germany defeated France 3–3 (5–4) in the first World Cup match ever decided by a penalty shoot-out.

July 11: Italy beat West Germany in the final to claim a third world title. Italian forward Paolo Rossi had gone straight from being suspended for match fixing to being selected for the World Cup [squad](#). He emerged as the tournament's top scorer and played a large part in helping his country win the title.

Mexico 1986

Mexico became the first country to host the World Cup twice.

The Mexican wave was performed at a World Cup for the first time, thereafter becoming globally associated with football.

June 22: On the eve of the quarterfinal against England, Argentina had to scramble for a suitable dark kit, and the improvised blue shirts worn by the players during the match became famous.

June 22: [Diego Maradona](#) scored both the “hand of God” goal and the “goal of the century” against England in one of the most famous individual performances in football history. ([Read “Was Maradona’s ‘Hand of God’ Goal Legal?”](#))

June 29: Argentina beat West Germany 3–2 in the final and lifted its second World Cup.

Italy 1990

Guide to football

Rules of the game

Football is played by two opposing teams of 11 players each. A team scores goals by putting a ball into the other team's net at one end of the playing field and simultaneously try to prevent the ball from being sent into their net at the other end.

The team that scores the most goals wins.



Touching the ball with the hands or arms, except by a designated player known as the goalkeeper, is illegal. Goalkeepers can only handle the ball inside a penalty area, a marked zone in front of each goal.

90-minute match, split into two halves



[Ireland](#) reached the quarterfinals without winning a match in regulation time, drawing in its three group stage matches and winning the first knockout round match in a penalty shoot-out.

June 23: [Cameroon](#) beat [Colombia](#) and became the first African side to reach the World Cup quarterfinals.

July 4: Footballer Paul Gascoigne bursting into tears

on camera during England's semifinal defeat against West Germany became one of the tournament's most famous moments.

July 8: West Germany beat Argentina 1–0 in the final and won a third World Cup.

The United States 1994

June 17: American singer [Diana Ross](#) famously missed a ceremonial penalty kick at the opening ceremony.

June 26: Bulgaria ended a World Cup winless streak stretching back to the 1962 tournament with a 4–0 win against Greece. The Bulgarian team advanced to the semifinals, and forward [Hristo Stoichkov](#) was one of the tournament's top goal scorers, along with [Russia's](#) Oleg Salenko.

June 28: Oleg Salenko scored five goals for Russia against Cameroon, setting a men's World Cup record for most goals scored by a player in a single match that still stands.

June 28: Cameroonian player [Roger Milla](#) became the [oldest scorer](#) in World Cup history at 42.

July 1: Diego Maradona tested positive for the drug [ephedrine](#) during the tournament and was immediately suspended. He never played an international match for Argentina again.

July 2: Colombian footballer Andrés Escobar was murdered in [Medellín](#) days after scoring an [inadvertent](#) own goal against the United States. ([Read "Was Andrés Escobar Killed for Scoring an Own Goal?"](#))

July 17: Brazil and Italy played the first goalless World Cup final, which became the first final decided by a penalty shoot-out. Italy's Roberto Baggio missed his penalty, and Brazil won a fourth title.

France 1998

[Croatia](#) reached the semifinals in its World Cup debut, and Croatian forward Davor Šuker won the Golden Boot awarded to the top goal scorer.

June 28: French footballer Laurent Blanc scored the first golden goal (an extra-time goal that ends a match, with the team that scores declared the winner) in World Cup history.

June 30: [David Beckham](#)'s red card against Argentina

became one of the defining controversies of the 1998 tournament, and England was eliminated on penalties after the match was drawn 2–2.

July 12: France beat Brazil 3–0 in the final and won its first World Cup. Brazilian forward [Ronaldo](#), one of the best players of the tournament, was hospitalized hours before the final and almost didn't play in the match. His [subpar](#) performance on the night is often cited as one of the main reasons for Brazil's loss.

South Korea and Japan 2002

This was the first World Cup held in Asia and the first cohosted by two countries.

April 11, 2001: Australia beat [American Samoa](#) 31–0 in a World Cup qualifying match, which remains the largest margin of victory in an international football match.

May 31, 2002: [Senegal](#) made its World Cup debut and beat reigning champions France 1–0 in the opening match of the tournament.

June 29: Turkish player Hakan Şükür scored after 11 seconds against South Korea in the third-place playoff, still the [fastest goal](#) in World Cup history.

June 30: Brazil beat Germany 2–0 in the final, and Ronaldo completed his redemption story by scoring both goals to help Brazil win a record fifth title.

Germany 2006

June 22: Referee Graham Poll infamously showed Croatian player Josip Šimunić three yellow cards during the country's group stage match against Australia. (See above [Australia vs. Chile at the 1974 World Cup](#).)

June 26: Switzerland was eliminated on penalties in the first knockout round against Ukraine, despite not having [conceded](#) a single goal in regulation time during the tournament.

July 9: In his final international match, France's [Zinedine Zidane](#) was sent off after headbutting Italian player Marco Materazzi in the final. Zidane still won the Golden Ball, awarded to the tournament's most valuable player. Italy won the final on penalties and claimed a fourth World Cup.

South Africa 2010

June 11: [South Africa](#) became the first African country to host the World Cup.

June 27: During the England vs. Germany Round of 16 match, English player Frank Lampard's shot hit the crossbar and bounced behind the goal line before German goalkeeper Manuel Neuer collected the ball. However, neither the referee nor the linesman awarded England the goal and, as goal-line technology had not been [implemented](#) at the time, the on-field decision stood. England went on to lose the match 4–1. The incident has been christened “Lampard’s ghost goal.”

July 2: Uruguayan forward Luis Suárez deliberately blocked a shot with his hand to prevent a goal in the quarterfinal. [Ghana](#)’s Asamoah Gyan missed the resulting penalty, and Uruguay later won the match in a penalty shoot-out.

July 11: Spain beat the Netherlands after extra time and won the World Cup for the first time.

Brazil 2014

Goal-line technology was used at the World Cup for the first time.

June 13: Dutch forward Robin van Persie scored with a “flying header” in a 5–1 victory against reigning champions Spain. It became one of the signature images of the tournament.

June 28: Colombian player James Rodríguez’s volley against Uruguay became one of the defining goals of the tournament.

July 8: Germany beat Brazil 7–1 in the semifinal, producing one of the most shocking scores in football history.

July 13: Germany beat Argentina in the final and claimed a fourth World Cup.

Russia 2018

The video assistant referee (VAR) system was used at the World Cup for the first time.

June 27: Germany became one of the rare defending champions to go out in the group stage, and it was the first time a German team had ever been eliminated in the group stage of a World Cup.

July 15: France beat Croatia 4–2 in the final and won

its second World Cup. French forward [Kylian Mbappé](#) became only the second teenager, [after Pelé](#), to score in a World Cup final.

Qatar 2022

This was the first World Cup staged in the [Middle East](#) and the first men's World Cup to be played in November and December.

November 22: [Saudi Arabia](#)'s 2–1 [comeback](#) win over Argentina became one of the biggest shocks of the modern World Cup era.

December 10: [Morocco](#) became the first African team and the first Arab team to reach the World Cup semifinals.

December 18: Argentine footballer [Lionel Messi](#) won the title in his fifth World Cup competition, beating France 3–3 (4–2) on penalties after a draw in regulation time. France's Kylian Mbappé scored a hat trick in the final, becoming the second player to do so after [England's Geoff Hurst](#).

Canada, Mexico, and the United States 2026

The tournament features 48 teams and 104 matches across three host countries, making it the first World Cup cohosted by three countries.

Mexico is the first country to host the men's World Cup three times.

June 11: The World Cup opened in [Mexico City](#).

July 19: The final will be played at the New York New Jersey Stadium in East Rutherford, [New Jersey](#).

World Cup winners



Brazil is the most successful team at the World Cup, winning a total of five titles in 1958, 1962, 1970, 1994, and 2002. Germany and Italy have won four titles each. Argentina, the 2022 World Cup winner, has won three championships. Uruguay and France have won two World Cups apiece, and England and Spain have each won the competition once.

Key People: [Gianni Infantino](#) • [Sepp Blatter](#) • [Zinedine Zidane](#) • [Birgit Prinz](#)

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On the Web: [Official Site of FIFA](#) (May 21, 2026)

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For a list of World Cup champions and award winners, see the table.

FIFA World Cup Award Winners				
year and host(s)	winning captain and team	runner-up	final match result	Golden Ball ¹
1930, Uruguay	José Nasazzi, Uruguay	Argentina	4–2	José Nasazzi (Uruguay)
1934, Italy	Gianpiero Combi, Italy	Czechoslovakia	2–1 (after extra time)	Giuseppe Meazza (Italy)
1938.	Giuseppe			Léônidas

France	Meazza, Italy	Hungary	4–2	(Brazil)	
1950, Brazil	Obdulio Varela, Uruguay	Brazil	2–1 ⁴	Zizinho (Brazil)	
1954, Switzerland	Fritz Walter, West Germany	Hungary	3–2	Ferenc Puskás (Hungary)	
1958, Sweden	Hilderaldo Bellini, Brazil	Sweden	5–2	Didi (Brazil)	
1962, Chile	Mauro Ramos, Brazil	Czechoslovakia	3–1	Garrincha (Brazil)	
1966, England	Bobby Moore, England	West Germany	4–2 (after extra time)	Bobby Charlton (England)	
1970, Mexico	Carlos Alberto, Brazil	Italy	4–1	Pelé (Brazil)	
1974, West Germany	Franz Beckenbauer, West Germany	Netherlands	2–1	Johan Cruyff (Netherlands)	
1978, Argentina	Daniel Passarella, Argentina	Netherlands	3–1 (after extra time)	Mario Kempes (Argentina)	
1982, Spain	Dino Zoff, Italy	West Germany	3–1	Paolo Rossi (Italy)	
1986, Mexico	Diego Maradona, Argentina	West Germany	3–2	Diego Maradona (Argentina)	
1990, Italy	Lothar Matthäus, West Germany	Argentina	1–0	Salvatore Schillaci (Italy)	
1994, United States	Dunga, Brazil	Italy	0–0 (3–2 on penalties)	Romário (Brazil)	
1998, France	Didier Deschamps, France	Brazil	3–0	Ronaldo (Brazil)	
2002, South Korea and Japan	Cafu, Brazil	Germany	2–0	Oliver Kahn (Germany)	
2006, Germany	Fabio Cannavaro, Italy	France	1–1 (5–3 on penalties)	Zinedine Zidane (France)	

2010, South Africa	Iker Casillas, Spain	Netherlands	1–0 (after extra time)	Diego Forlán (Uruguay)
2014, Brazil	Philipp Lahm, Germany	Argentina	1–0 (after extra time)	Lionel Messi (Argentina)
2018, Russia	Hugo Lloris, France	Croatia	4–2	Luka Modrić (Croatia)
2022, Qatar	Lionel Messi, Argentina	France	3–3 (4–2 on penalties)	Lionel Messi (Argentina)

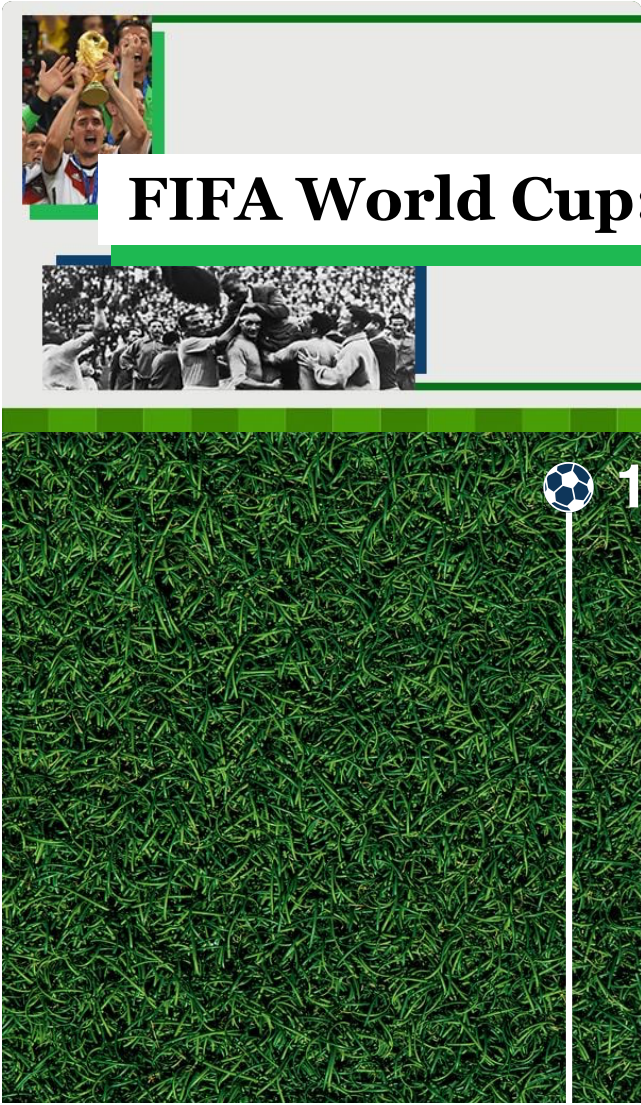
¹Known as Player of the Tournament until 1978.

²Presented to the top goal scorer and officially named the Golden Boot in 2010

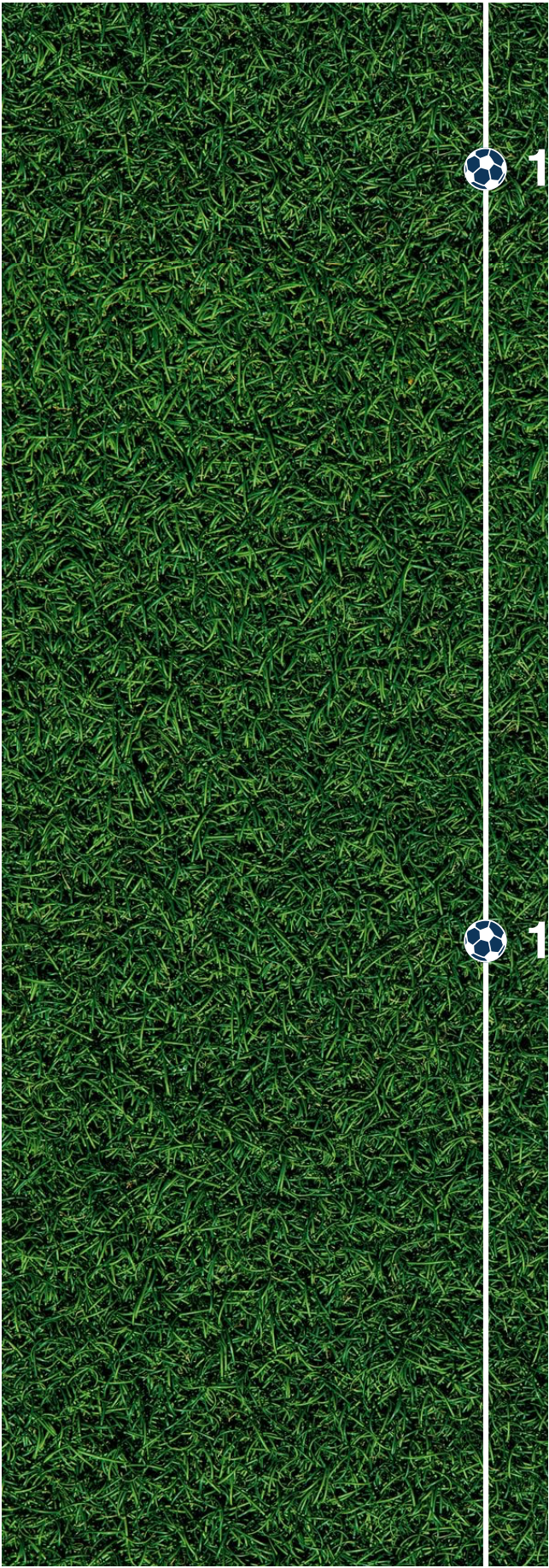
³Lists goalkeepers selected for the All-Star teams until 1994; from 1994 to 201 Yashin Award.

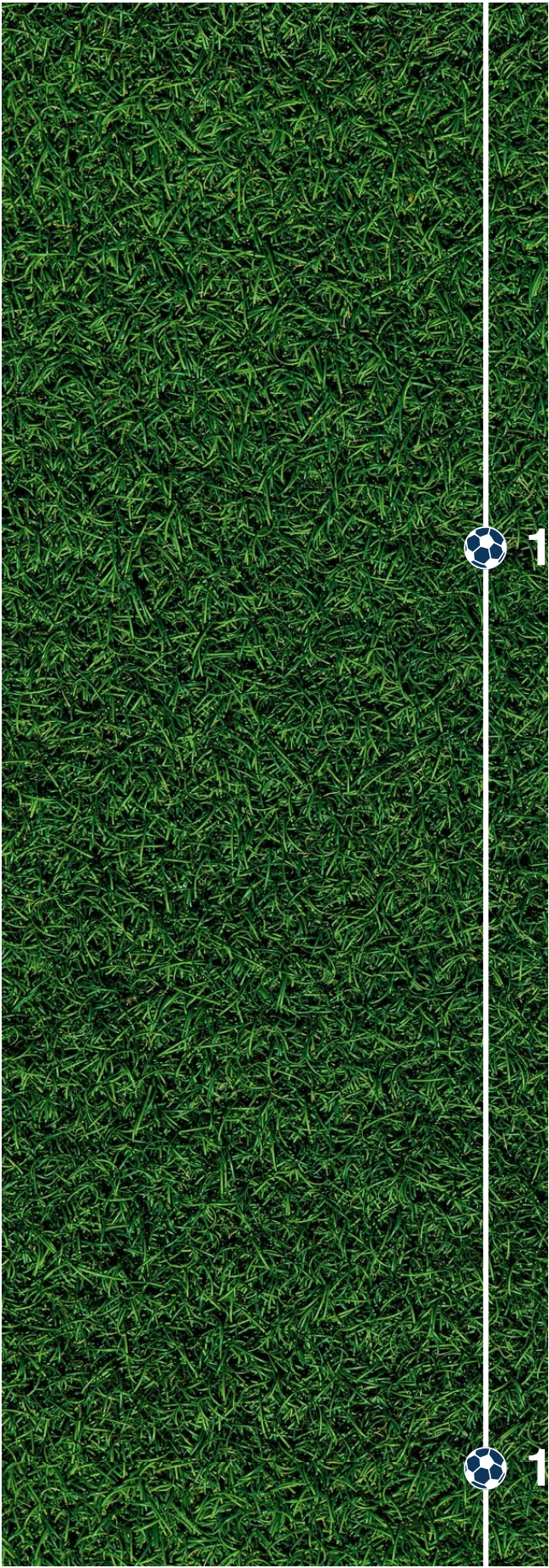
⁴Decisive final group stage match.

Timeline of the World Cup’s history

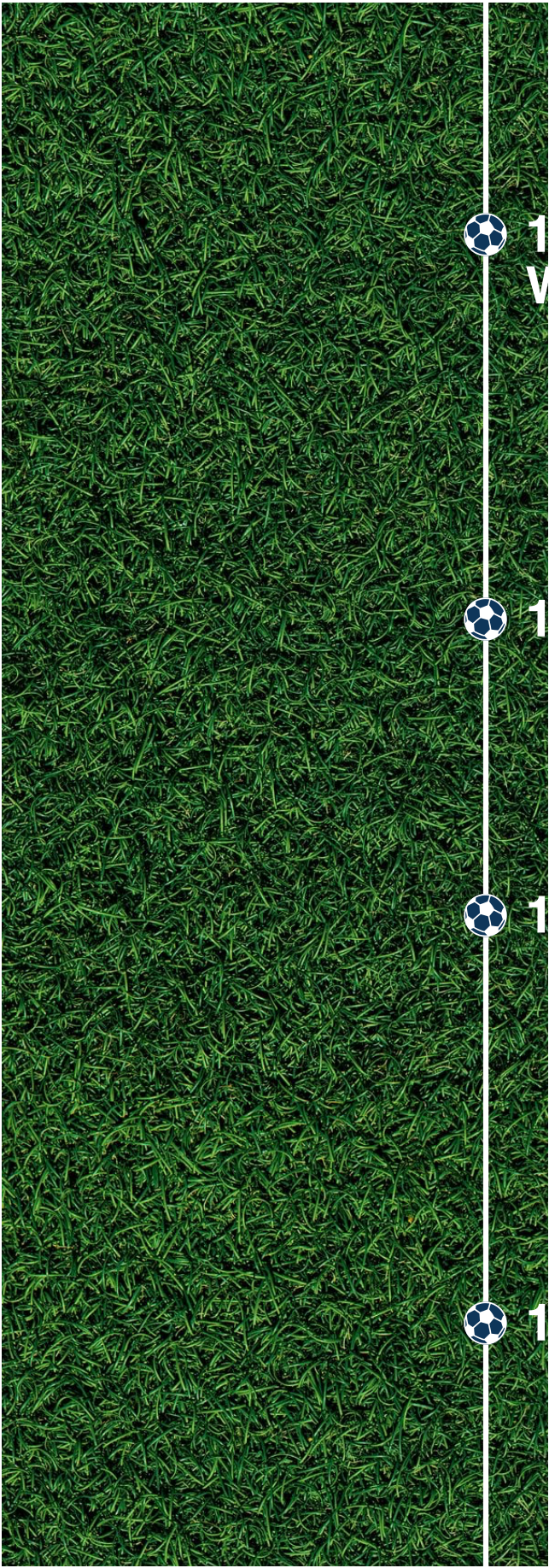


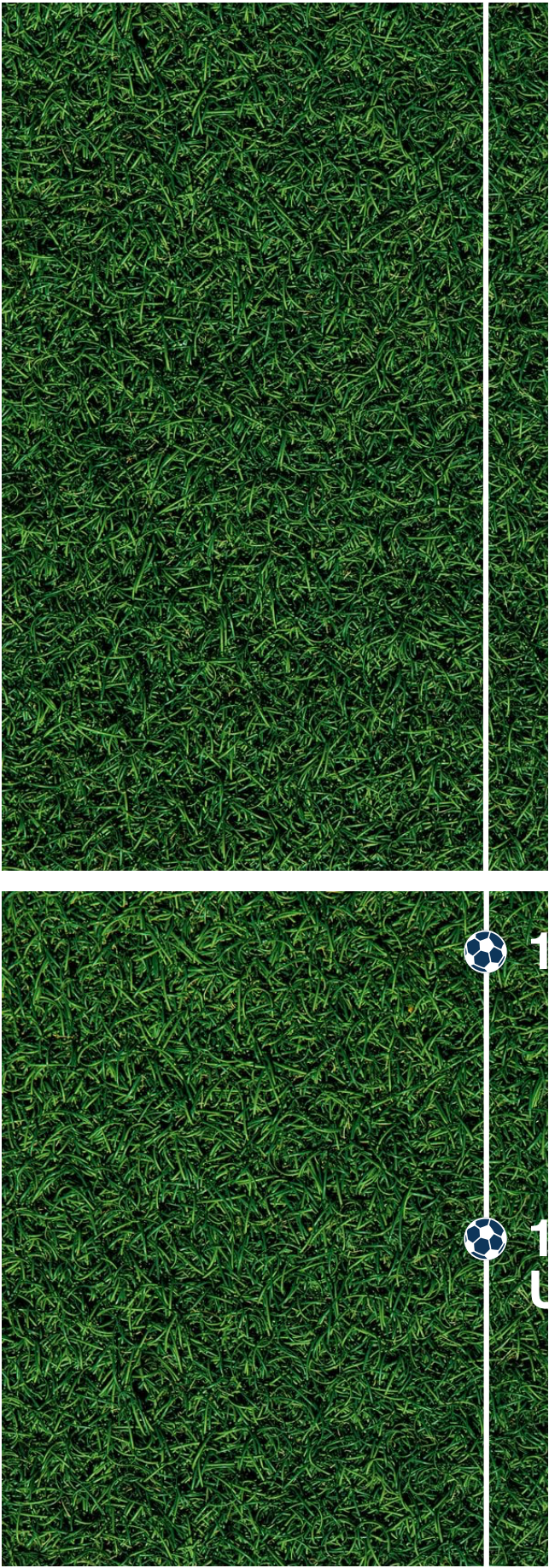


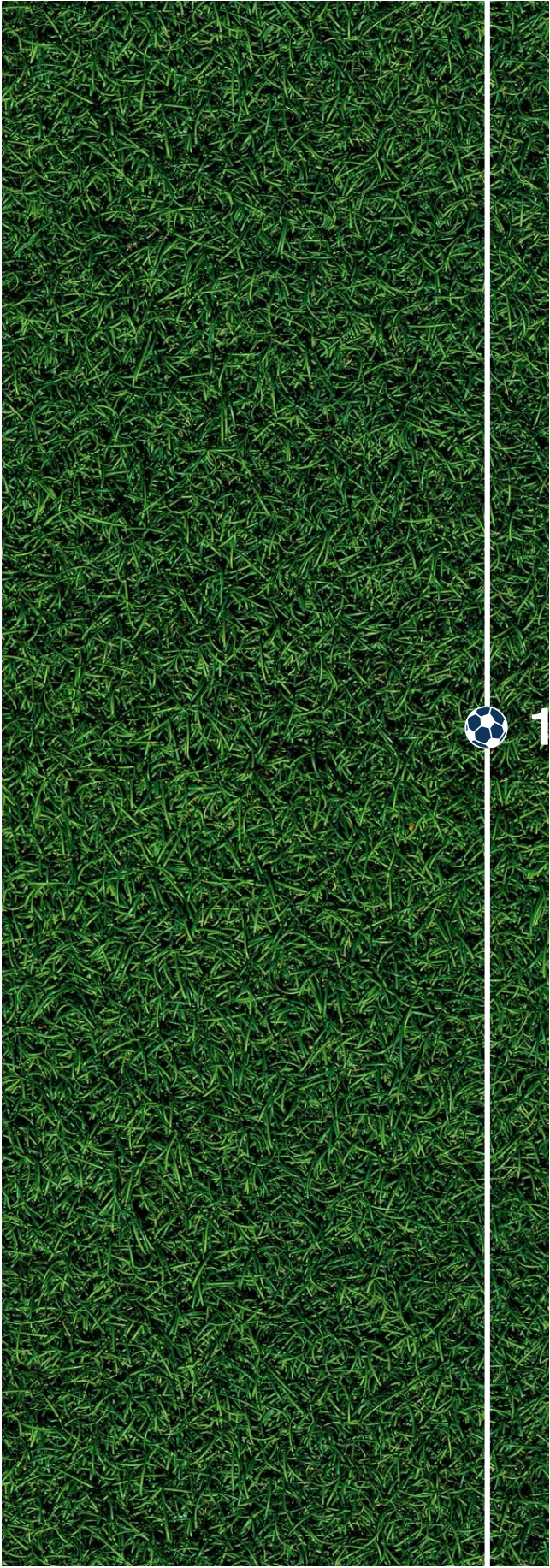






















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Argentina celebrating its 2022 World Cup victory Team captain Lionel Messi (holding trophy) and other members [... \(more\)](#)

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- What is FIFA? 
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- What is the main role of FIFA in world soccer? 
- How does FIFA organize international soccer tournaments? 
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FIFA, world governing body of association [football](#) (soccer), founded in [Paris](#) in 1904. FIFA is headquartered in [Zürich](#), and its membership includes more than 200 national football associations. As association football’s governing authority, FIFA sets the rules of play, establishes standards for refereeing and coaching, oversees international player transfers, organizes the World Cup (both [men’s](#) and [women’s](#)) and other international tournaments, and promotes the global development of the [sport](#).

History



Pelé in action Brazilian forward Pelé (third from left) during the 1970 World Cup final match between Brazil and Italy in Mexico City. Brazil defeated Italy, 4–1, to capture its third World Cup championship. [... \(more\)](#)

Football developed in [England](#), where an attempt at [codifying](#) rules began in the 1840s. As the sport spread to [Europe](#), [South America](#), and elsewhere around the globe, local and national leagues began developing. The spread of international matches in the early 20th century led for calls to establish global rules. Seven countries—[Belgium](#), [Denmark](#), [France](#), [the Netherlands](#), [Spain](#), [Sweden](#), and [Switzerland](#)—founded FIFA in Paris in 1904. [Germany](#) was not represented at the meeting in Paris, although it played a role in FIFA's founding. At the founding meeting, Robert Guérin, a French journalist who led the effort to create the organization, was elected as FIFA's first president; he served until 1906.

England (where the powerful [Football Association](#) [FA] had been established in 1863) did not join until 1906. That year, English football executive Daniel Woolfall was elected as FIFA's president, a position that he held until his death in 1918. Under his leadership, the rules of football were further standardized, and the first international football tournament was established for the [1908 Olympics](#). FIFA also created an exception to its one-association-per-country rule under Woolfall's leadership, enabling separate Irish, Scottish, and Welsh associations to join by 1911. In the early 1910s, FIFA expanded beyond Europe as [Argentina](#), [Chile](#), [South Africa](#), the [United States](#), and others joined. This growth spurred the initiation of an international tournament separate from the Olympics under the leadership of FIFA's third president, French football administrator Jules Rimet (1921–54).

The first FIFA [World Cup](#) tournament was hosted by [Uruguay](#) in 1930. Thirteen countries participated, and Uruguay defeated Argentina 4–2 in the championship match. The United States finished third. Noticeably absent was England, which had withdrawn from FIFA in 1928 over concerns about the [encroaching](#) power of FIFA over the FA. England rejoined in 1946 and played in its first World Cup in 1950. The Men's World Cup tournament has been held every four years, except during and just after [World War II](#). Traditionally played in either [Europe](#) or [South America](#), the Men's World Cup was first hosted in [North America](#) in 1970 ([Mexico](#)), in [Asia](#) in 2002 (cohosted by Japan and [South Korea](#)), in [Africa](#) in 2010 ([South Africa](#)), and in the [Middle East](#) in 2022 ([Qatar](#)).



1991 U.S. Women's National Team The U.S. Women's National Team at the inaugural Women's World Cup tournament in Guangzhou, China, in November 1991. Picture shows: (back row) Joy Biefield, Carla Werden,...[\(more\)](#)

After World War II FIFA's membership grew rapidly, to more than 100 members in the 1960s and more than 200 in the early 21st century. As the World Cup's popularity grew, so did the number of teams in the tournament. Sixteen teams qualified for the men's tournament from 1954 to 1978, 24 from 1982 to 1994, and 32 from 1998 to 2022. In 2017 FIFA approved a plan to expand the number of qualifying teams to 48 for the [2026 Men's World Cup](#), which will be the first tournament cohosted by three countries: the United States, Mexico, and [Canada](#). In November 2025 FIFA president [Gianni Infantino](#) announced the establishment of the FIFA Peace Prize, which will be awarded annually to "individuals who have taken exceptional and extraordinary actions for peace."

In 1991 China hosted the first FIFA [Women's World Cup](#), which is held every four years, usually one year after the men's tournament. The U.S. team won the [inaugural](#) tournament, defeating Norway 2–1 in the championship match. In 1991 and 1995 the tournament featured 12 teams. The field expanded to 16 teams in 1999 and 24 teams in 2015 and 2019. [Australia](#) and [New Zealand](#) were selected in 2020 to cohost 32 teams in the 2023 tournament.

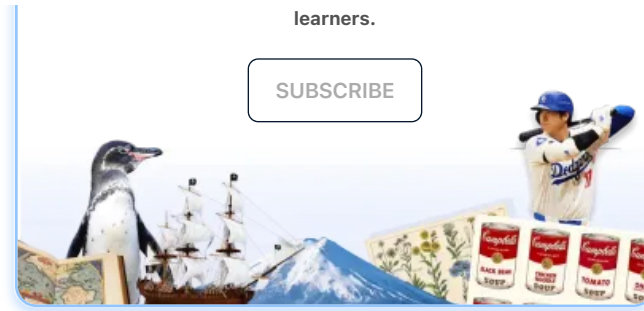


Structure

FIFA is led by a secretary-general who oversees the organization's operations. The FIFA Council, a strategic oversight body consisting of 37 members, appoints the secretary-general. The FIFA Council is headed by a president and eight vice presidents. Members are elected to four-year terms and may serve no more than three terms. The main legislative body is the FIFA [Congress](#), and each of the national organizations has one delegate in the Congress. The Congress elects the president, approves the budget, and chooses the location of future World Cup tournaments. The Football Tribunal, created in 2021, resolves disputes and makes decisions on regulatory applications. The universal rules that govern the play of football are independently maintained by the International Football Association Board (IFAB), the organization that determines which rules to introduce or discontinue. FIFA joined the IFAB in 1913 and holds half of the votes (the other half are controlled by England, [Scotland](#), [Wales](#), and [Northern Ireland](#)). Each national association belongs to one of six regional confederations, covering Africa (CAF), Asia (AFC), Europe (UEFA), South America (CONMEBOL), [Oceania](#) (OFC), and [North America](#), [Central America](#), and the [Caribbean](#) (CONCACAF).

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Controversies

FIFA has been beset by numerous controversies, some surrounding the selection of World Cup host countries. [Italy](#) hosted the 1934 World Cup, a decision criticized as [normalizing](#) its fascist government under [dictator Benito Mussolini](#). [Russia](#) and Qatar were selected as hosts in 2018 and 2022, respectively. Both selections were criticized because of the host countries' intolerance toward the [LGBTQ+ community](#), as well as Russia's invasion of [Crimea](#) and allegations against Qatar relating to its treatment of workers.

FIFA has also been the subject of allegations of financial improprieties, including [fraud](#) and [money laundering](#). In 2010 Chuck Blazer, the head of CONCACAF, was targeted by the [U.S. Federal Bureau of Investigation](#) (FBI) for accepting bribes related to the 1998 and 2010 Men's World Cup tournaments. Blazer entered a guilty plea and became an informant against other corrupt FIFA officials.

In full: Fédération Internationale de Football Association

English: International Federation of Association Football

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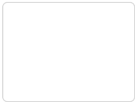
On the Web: [Official Site of FIFA](#) (May 21, 2026)

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The [2015 FIFA corruption scandal](#) erupted when the [U.S. Department of Justice](#) (DOJ) released a 47-count criminal indictment charging seven FIFA officials with accepting \$150 million in bribes over two decades. Eventually, more than two dozen sports marketing executives and high-ranking FIFA officials were implicated in a [bribery](#) scheme connected to the awarding of hosting rights for the 2018

Men’s World Cup to Russia and the [2022 Men’s World Cup](#) to Qatar. In response to the scandal, FIFA launched several reforms intended to foster transparency and better governance, including the formation of the Audit and [Compliance](#) Committee in 2016.

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2026 FIFA World Cup



2022 FIFA World Cup



Football World Cup



Women’s World Cup

Michael Levy

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